

“Shields, helmets and coats of mail were shivered by the **furious and impatient thrusts of his sword**; some he dashed to earth with his shield”

ORDERIC VITALIS, ON WILLIAM THE CONQUEROR AT HASTINGS, c. 1130CE



▲ THE BATTLE OF LECHFELD

In 955CE, at Lechfeld, European armoured horsemen led by Otto I defeated the previously invincible Magyars. The victory was achieved through a decisive cavalry charge, assisted by the use of stirrups.

◀ THE BATTLE OF HASTINGS

Following William, Duke of Normandy's invasion of England, Anglo-Saxon and Norman infantry and cavalry clashed at Hastings, in 1066.

KEY EVENTS

500–1100

■ **From 533CE** Emperor Justinian tries and fails to restore the Roman Empire in North Africa and Italy; the eastern half of the empire becomes the Byzantine Empire.

■ **c.677CE** The Byzantines use the incendiary weapon known as “Greek fire” against Arab forces besieging Constantinople.

■ **752CE** Pepin the Short becomes the first Carolingian king of the Franks.

■ **793CE** Vikings use longships to cross the North Sea and plunder the monastery of Lindisfarne, in northern England, signalling the beginning of the period of Viking raids around the coasts of Europe.

■ **c.800CE** The Franks develop high-quality swords of hardened and tempered steel.

■ **800CE** Charlemagne, the Frankish king, is crowned Emperor of the Romans by Pope Leo III in Rome.

■ **900CE** Franks and Normans begin to fight on horseback, using the stirrup and improved saddles.

■ **911CE** Viking invaders form the Duchy of Normandy in northern France.

■ **1015–1026** Danish warrior, Canute, creates a North Sea empire, ruling England and Scandinavia.



of wood, but now featuring a keep on top of an earth mound as a central strongpoint. Until the 10th century, horsemen had mostly dismounted to fight, but the adoption in Europe of stirrups and of a saddle with a raised pommel and cantle (backrest) made the horse an effective fighting platform. The efficacy of mounted combat was demonstrated in 955CE, when Otto I of Germany

defeated the Magyars by armoured cavalry charge. At first, mounted troops wielded spears overarm, as the Normans did against an Anglo-Saxon infantry shield wall at Hastings in 1066. However, fifteen years later, at the battle of Dyrrachium in southern Italy, Norman horseman could be seen charging with lances held underarm – a tactic that became the trademark of later medieval European warfare.